

01

When to Start

The sweet spot is 27–32 months. Look for 10 or more:

- Keeps diaper dry for 90+ minutes
- Shows awareness before going (pauses, squats, goes quiet)
- Pulls pants up and down independently
- Follows simple two-step instructions
- Communicates needs with words or gestures
- Shows interest in the toilet or underwear
- Bothered by wet or soiled diapers
- Can walk to potty and sit independently
- Bowel movements roughly on a schedule
- Understands: wet, dry, potty
- Says "me do it" or "by myself" about things
- Sits still in one spot for 2+ minutes
- Curious about what adults/siblings do in bathroom
- Pauses briefly before an accident

03

Words That Work

Positive language shortens stool refusal. Negative language makes it last longer. (Taubman et al., 2003)

USE	AVOID
"You did it!"	"You're a big kid now."
"Let's try the potty."	"Why didn't you tell me?"
"Poop goes in the potty."	"That's gross."
"Accidents happen."	"You should know better."
"Your body is learning."	"Diapers forever?"
"Let's try later."	"Just go!"

02

The Method

90%+ success rate in clinical studies (Butler, 1976).

- 1

Naked at Home Days 1–2

No pants, no pressure. Potty nearby. They connect feeling to action. Prompt every 30 min.
- 2

Commando Days 2–3

Loose pants, no underwear. Still at home. They feel wetness and manage clothing.
- 3

Underwear Days 4–6

Real underwear at home. Accidents are expected and normal. Use the accident protocol.
- 4

The Real World Week 2+

Short outings first. Travel potty in the car. Gradually extend distance and duration.

04

When It Goes Wrong

Your reaction matters more than the accident.

- Stay calm.** Neutral face, neutral voice.
- Narrate.** "Your body had an accident. Let's clean up."
- Involve them.** Hand them a towel.
- Redirect.** Sit on potty, 30 seconds.
- Move on.** No shame. Resume play.

ALSO IN THE PLAYBOOK

- + The Poop Chapter (stool refusal & withholding)
- + Nighttime dryness (why you can't train it)
- + Boys vs. Girls (what research says)
- + 3-day method deep dive
- + Regression recovery protocol
- + Daycare & travel strategies
- + When to call your pediatrician